recently united kingdoms out of foreign conflicts. However, in the later years of his reign, James unwittingly dragged England, Scotland and Ireland into what became the Thirty Years' War. The war took place from 1618 to 1648 and was one of the deadliest wars to ever occur in Europe. Historians believe it was the tension between the Protestants, Catholics and Calvinists that fueled the war. Each religious group had formed their own league and was looking to gain power over the others.

In 1625, King James I of England died and his second son King Charles I ascended to the throne. In the early years of his rule, Charles succeeded in alienating many of his peers and subjects. Already an unpopular figure with a reputation for being severe and arrogant, Charles inherited the Duke of Buckingham as his principal Minister. If Charles was unpopular in Parliament, then the Duke of Buckingham was practically detested. Unfortunately, Charles did not inherit his father's desire for peace. Under instruction from Buckingham, he threw his kingdoms whole-heartedly into the ongoing fight against the Catholic forces.

Charles became steadily more unpopular with his subjects across the three kingdoms. To generate income, Charles resorted to reviving a tax that had not been seen since the Elizabethan times. The "ship money" levy was an annual tax on seaports and coastal towns that was collected to pay for the Royal Navy. In 1635, Charles applied this tax to inland towns and began collecting from any citizen who had the means to pay. Parliament and tax-paying citizens were shocked at what they considered to be an illegal tax imposed by the king. In the same year, Charles introduced a series of ecclesiastical reforms in England. Charles' Queen Henrietta Maria of France was openly Catholic at court. So was William Laud, who was the close adviser of Charles and the archbishop of Canterbury. Many English Protestants including the more zealous puritans were suspicious of the increase in "popery" in England and feared that Charles was trying to restore the Catholic faith.

It seemed that Charles had only a few supporters at first. The majority of the English nobility and landed gentry were reluctant to pledge allegiance so early in the war but there were those who believed in the "Divine Right